

War had “the bomb.” The chief function of air forces to the east and west of the Iron Curtain was to anticipate and intercept an enemy nuclear attack and penetrate enemy air defenses to deliver a nuclear strike of their own. In 1947 the independent US Air Force (USAF) was created to replace the AAF. Within it, in recognition of the importance of the nuclear role, the Strategic Air Command (SAC) was established to handle the nuclear bomber force.

In the days before the introduction of intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs) and reconnaissance satellites – that is, through to the early 1960s – the nuclear confrontation was almost exclusively a business for aircraft and airmen. High-altitude

spyplanes kept watch on enemy military preparations, providing photos of potential targets and air-defense installations. High-performance jet interceptors stood ready to scramble against incoming bombers. They would be directed by a chain of early-warning radar stations spread out across the north of Canada and Greenland down into Britain, feeding information to control rooms in underground bunkers. And above all there were the strategic

bombers. Those theorists of aerial warfare in the 1920s and 1930s who had believed bombers were invincible and could win a war quickly on their own seemed to have been proved wrong in World War II. But the nuclear age, in an unforeseen manner, made them seem prescient. Now a bomber force really could, in principle, deliver a shock attack that would end a war in days. At least a few bombers would always get through, and armed with such destructive power, that was enough.

#### ROCKET-ASSISTED BOMBER

*A Boeing B-47 jet bomber makes a jet-assisted takeoff. The aircraft needed the extra boost to lift off the ground with a full load of bombs and fuel. Short on range, it was turned into a credible intercontinental nuclear bomber by in-flight refueling.*

